When Play Is Denied: Childhood, Safety, and the Lessons We Carry

(Editor's Note

At Makkala Jagriti, our work in early childhood education is rooted in a simple belief: children learn best when they feel safe. As we deepen our engagement with play-based, child-centric approaches, we often find ourselves reflecting not only on systems and structures, but on the childhood experiences that shape who we become.

In this personal reflection, Neeraja Anupama, Senior Coordinator, Communications, revisits her own early years and the subtle ways in which play, safety, and emotional security were negotiated within school spaces. Her story reminds us that conversations about early childhood are never abstract, they are deeply personal, and they stay with us long after childhood ends.)

I have been working in the education field for the past three years, and as part of our organisation's branding journey, we are stepping into a new venture that is slowly taking shape. As we build this, we often find ourselves in deep conversations about early childhood, why it matters, what children truly need, and how learning should look in the early years.

One theme keeps returning in these discussions: **the importance of play and how current systems often disrupt it.**

Colleagues who work closely in early childhood education, many of whom are parents themselves, speak about how play supports not just learning, but emotional regulation, curiosity, and a sense of safety. They also speak about how, as a system, we impose formal learning far too early, often taking away the joy and freedom that should define childhood.

These conversations took me back to my own early years.

As a child, I remember feeling constantly alert, as though the world around me was something I had to manage carefully. Anganwadis did not offer much support back then, so my early learning mostly happened outside formal spaces, walking with my grandmother, visiting relatives, and waiting for my parents to return from school.

I was an anxiously attached child, and the idea of going to nursery school filled me with dread. Every morning felt like an ordeal. Being packed into a school jeep was like being squeezed into an *idiappam* mould, tight, suffocating, with only a thin sliver of light once

we finally reached school. I cried almost every day, convinced that this separation from my mother was final.

When I eventually moved to my mother's school, things became slightly easier. Simply knowing she was nearby gave me a sense of safety. Yet school remained a place where I felt constantly watched and corrected.

My first-grade teacher's main complaint about me was, *"This child only wants to play. She doesn't want to learn."*

I remember standing beside her table, asking every hour, *"Teacher, can we go and play, please?"* Often, I would be shamed or scolded for asking.

But it didn't stop there.

I was shamed for wanting to play. I was shamed for how my teeth looked, with a teacher commenting that I didn't brush well. I remember spending two hours of the next morning brushing my teeth, and I am not exaggerating.

I remember being picked on repeatedly, compared with the other students, corrected for one thing or another, until I became hyper-aware of myself. When I was made a class monitor at the age of seven, I would lecture other children about sitting silently, yet I never wrote anyone's name down for misbehaving. I was terrified of making a mistake, of spelling a name wrong, of being judged.

At seven years old, I was already scanning my environment for danger.

There were moments when I was forced to do things against my will, being asked to participate in events as a last-minute substitute, pushed into situations without consent, and expected to perform despite fear. Almost being denied a choice!

What looked like discipline from the outside felt like brute force from the inside.

For a long time, I didn't question any of this. I simply grew into an anxious adult constantly reading rooms, scanning faces, anticipating judgement, and making choices driven more by fear than clarity.

Only much later did I begin to ask myself: Why am I so afraid of my surroundings?

Now, I cannot unsee the connection.

What I experienced was not a lack of ability or motivation. It was a lack of **emotional safety**. Play, where children feel free, accepted, and unafraid, was treated as a

distraction rather than a necessity. And without safety, learning became something to survive, not enjoy.

Yesterday's conversation about early childhood made me unexpectedly emotional. I felt a strange grief for my younger self and for every child who has had to shrink, comply, or silence themselves in order to be "good."

What I experienced was not an individual failure, mine or my teachers'. It was institutional. Many early learning spaces are designed to manage children efficiently, often at the cost of their emotional worlds. In such systems, obedience is prioritised over understanding, silence over expression, and control over care.

Within these structures, play becomes inconvenient. It disrupts order, demands flexibility, and gives children agency. When safety is missing, even play becomes controlled and performative, another task to be completed rather than a space to feel free.

Breaking this pattern requires more than introducing play-based activities. It requires reimagining early childhood spaces as places of emotional safety where adults slow down, observe before correcting, listen before labelling, and understand behaviour as communication rather than defiance.

Looking back, I realise that the child who kept asking to play was not resisting learning. She was asking to be seen, to feel safe, and to exist without fear.

And that is not something any child should have to ask for. It should be the starting point of education.